nominate him. Therefore, even though in terms of line management the village tract leader and village headman should be working closely together, they are in fact loosely linked because the village tract leader serves the interests of the PNO, whereas the village headman serves the villagers.

The advantage in having both a carrot and stick to control villagers serves to explain why the PNO retained its seats in 2015 despite challenges from the NLD and UPNO. The regime seems to have appointed the right brokers to help it deliver political objectives, and in the process helped maintain order in the frontier area by decentralizing power without losing control.

The regime also tried to recruit brokers in the southern Shan State. Since the SNLD was pro-democracy, the SNDP became the regime's next best choice. The party's major source of income is the Top White Tiger Company owned by the party chairman and party directors. The company obtained a gypsum-mining concession from the regime, and an application for a copper mining concession is in progress.[28] But the links between the regime and the party in the political economy were not as strong as between the regime and the PNO, and unlike the PNO, the SNDP has no armed force to back it.

In the 2010 election, the SNDP won three seats in the Amyotha Hluttaw, eighteen seats in the Pyithu Hluttaw, and thirty-six seats in the State/Regional Hluttaw. The positive result could be attributed to two factors. First, the NLD and SNLD did not participate in the election. Second, the USDP collaborated with SNDP by not contesting in the constituencies where the SNDP was strong. In an interview with its chairman in the party's Taunggyi office the day before the election in 2015, he was confident that his party would retain all its seats and could even be the kingmaker if the USDP and NLD tied. As it turned out, the election was almost a complete whitewash for the party — it lost all its seats in the Amyotha and Pyithu Hluttaws and managed to get only one seat in the State/Regional Assembly.

In contrast, in 2015 the SNLD — which boycotted the election in 2010 — won twelve seats in the Pyithu Hluttaw, three seats in the Amyotha Hluttaw, and twenty-five seats in the State/Regional Hluttaw. Its election victory to an extent reflected the Shan people's genuine desire for self-determination and democracy, and their contempt for the SNDP. However, could the party have achieved that number of seats without some muscle at its back? The SNLD is close to the RCSS/SSA-S and has backed the latter in the past.[29] Close scrutiny of where the SNLD got its seats reveals